Wildlife crossings

Many different species cross naturally between separate habitat patches. This movement can be seasonal, as in annual migrations, or prompted by natural disasters, such as fire or flood, or may take place over long timespans. It creates connections that are often essential for the health and survival of species and communities, providing renewal or new resources at pivotal moments. Increasingly, however, human-made barriers, such as clearances for agriculture, road, railroads, and urban sprawl, are breaking up this natural interflow from one habitat to another. The idea of providing wildlife with ways through is not new. For example, fishways for fish to bypass dams go back centuries. Wildlife crossings—from bridges for bears in Canada to tunnels for California's desert tortoises—are becoming an increasingly common feature of construction work. Thousands of crossings, among them bridges, viaducts, and underpasses—often planted with vegetation—have been built to conserve habitats and to avoid fatal collisions between animals and vehicles.

See also: Competitive exclusion principle • The ecosystem • The neutral theory of biodiversity • Metapopulations • Halting biodiversity loss